

FRIGHTFUL TRAGEDY.

FIVE CHILDREN MURDERED BY THEIR FATHER.

Between five and six o'clock on Wednesday night a shocking tragedy was perpetrated at Walthamstow, near Stratford, Essex, Wm. Gouldstone having drowned three of his children—Charles, aged about three years; Herbert, two years; and Frederick, aged sixteen months—and so seriously assaulted two others, twin boys, aged only seven days, that they died during the night. Gouldstone, who is a blacksmith employed by a firm in Lower Thames-street, London, lives at No. 8, Courtney-place, adjoining St. James-street, Walthamstow, and is thirty-five years of age. Last week his wife was confined of twins, and she had a woman in the house to nurse her. On Wednesday evening Gouldstone returned from work rather earlier than usual, and the nurse noticed that he was in a very bad mood. He said he wanted her to leave the house while he had a chat with his wife concerning the money that was to be paid to the doctor. The woman left the house, but just before going she heard Gouldstone ask for the boy Frederick, and noticed that the lad seemed pleased at this parental recognition. Shortly afterwards she was surprised at seeing the cistern overflowing, and going to it was horrified at discovering the dead bodies of three of the children in it. At the same time she heard screams proceeding from the room where Mrs Gouldstone was recovering after her confinement. She knocked at the door, but being unable to gain admission, obtained assistance, and the door was burst open. It was then found that the enraged father, after drowning his three eldest children, had struck the twin babies at their mother's breast with a hammer. The police were sent for, and Gouldstone was taken to the Lea Bridge police station. When the nurse asked the prisoner what he had done, he replied, "Never mind; I am happy now, and she is a single woman." No motive can be assigned for the crime except that prisoner indicated by his complaints that his wife had had too many children. Since her confinement last week he had not spoken to her. He was a most abstemious man, his wife stating that she had never but once seen him the worse for drink, and his ordinary good character is shown by his having been in his present situation five or six years.

PRISONER BEFORE THE MAGISTRATES.

At Stratford to-day (Thursday) Gouldstone, charged with murdering, on Wednesday night, three of his children, aged respectively three and a-half, two and a-half, and sixteen months, by drowning, and further with murdering his infants, aged seven days each, by striking them on the head with a hammer. Mrs Hamilton, monthly nurse, deposed that while absent from the bedroom on Wednesday evening she heard Mrs Gouldstone scream, and running in she found the prisoner had attacked the twins with a hammer, and he told her the other three children were in the cistern. She followed the prisoner down stairs, and met him coming into the kitchen with the youngest of the first three children in his arms, apparently dead. She was so horrified that she ran back to her bedroom, and stayed ten minutes. When she returned she found the three elder children in a row on the floor dead from drowning. The twins died during the night. Prisoner was remanded.